

Week 4 — Tongue Diagnosis

EAM310 · EAST ASIAN MEDICINE DIAGNOSIS I · VUIM SUMMER 2026

△ Quiz 3 — July 31, 2026

Class: Friday August 1, 2026 · 9AM–1PM
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REQUIRED READINGS — DUE BEFORE AUGUST 1

FCM CHAPTER 23 — MACIOCIA

- Clinical significance of tongue diagnosis
- Tongue body: color, shape, movement
- Tongue coating: color, thickness, moisture
- Topography — organ zone mapping
- Three layers: Wei, Ying, Yuan

ANN CECIL-STERMAN — TONGUE DX BOOK

- Recommended by Prof. Schrier for Week 4
- Clinical photographs of tongue findings
- Pattern correlations with tongue evidence
- Practical observation guidelines
- Integration with pulse and pattern diagnosis

WEEK 4 LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Identify clinical significance of tongue diagnosis
- Describe the three tongue layers (Wei/Ying/Yuan)
- Map organ zones on the tongue (3 Burner topography)
- Recognize peeling, geographic, and mirror tongue
- Interpret tongue body color (pale, red, purple, blue)
- Interpret tongue coating (color, thickness, moisture)
- Identify tongue body shape findings and their patterns
- Apply tongue diagnosis to clinical case examples

ASSESSMENT CALENDAR

Date	Event	Material Covered
Jul 31	△ Quiz 3	Week 3 material — Pulse Diagnosis, 28 Qualities, Seasonal Pulses
Aug 1	Week 4 Class	Tongue Diagnosis — body color, shape, coating, topography
Aug 7	MIDTERM + Journal 1–25	Weeks 1–4 comprehensive
Aug 21	Quiz 4	Week 4+ material
Sep 11	FINAL + Journal 26–50	Weeks 6–9 comprehensive

IN-CLASS PRACTICE — WHAT TO EXPECT

TONGUE OBSERVATION LAB

Week 4 includes partner tongue observation practice. Come ready to:

- Observe partner's tongue under natural light — tip to root, body then coat
- Record body color, shape, coat color, coat thickness, moisture in your journal
- Practice identifying at least one zone finding and correlating to organ
- Document findings (Journal entry counts toward midterm — entries 1–25 due Aug 7)

Tongue Layers		
THREE LAYERS 三層		
Judge	anti-pathogenic Qi	Exuberance or decline of Zheng Qi
Distinguish	thermal nature	Heat vs Cold; Full vs Empty
Detect	disease location	Organ zone tells you WHERE
Predict	disease course	Tongue changes as disease progresses
Key Rule: The tongue body color always shows the true condition — even when other signs are misleading (False Heat/Cold)		

Tongue Zones		
Zone	Organ(s)	Key Finding
Tip	Heart 心	Red tip = Heart-Fire; depressed tip = Heart constraint
Just behind tip	Lung 肺	Swollen front = Phlegm in Lungs
Sides	Liver / Gallbladder 肝膽	Red sides = LV-Fire; reddish-purple sides = LV Blood stasis
Center oval	Spleen / Stomach 脾胃	Central crack = ST-Yin def; swollen center = Phlegm-Damp in MJ
Root / Back	KD · BL · Intestines	Rootless coat = KD-Yin def; thick root coat = Damp-Heat in LJ
Contralateral rule: Left tongue side = Right breast; Right tongue side = Left breast (breast cancer screening in CM)		

3-BURNER DIVISION (KIRSCHBAUM 2000)	
Anterior 1/3	Upper Jiao — Heart / Lung
Middle 1/3	Middle Jiao — Spleen / Stomach / LV / GB
Posterior 1/3	Lower Jiao — Kidney / Bladder / SI / LI

OBSERVATION CONDITIONS	
Lighting	Natural light only — fluorescent distorts color
Sequence	Tip → middle → root, 5–15 sec max
Diet/Meds	Nothing coloring 30 min before
Season	Tongue shifts seasonally — factor in borderline findings
Age	Children: redder normal; Elderly: drier, paler, contracted = normal

Tongue Body & Coat	
1. Body Color	Blood · Nutritive Qi · Yin organs · Heat/Cold · Yin/Yang def
2. Body Shape	Blood · Nutritive Qi · Excess vs Deficiency
3. Coating	Yang organs · pathogenic factors · Heat/Cold · Excess/Def
4. Moisture	State of Body Fluids

Color	Indicates	Key Clinical Details (from slides)
Pale Red	Normal	Slightly moist · thin white coat · not swollen or thin · sublingual veins not distended
Pale	Qi/Blood def · Yang def	Slightly pale = Qi def · Pale + dry = Blood def · Pale on sides = LV Blood def · Pale + wet = Yang def · Pale + swollen center + teethmarks = SP-Qi def
Red	Heat (Full or Empty)	Red + coating = Full-Heat · Red without coating = Empty-Heat · Red tip = Heart-Fire (w/ coat) or HT Empty-Heat (w/o coat) · Red sides + coat = LV-Fire or GB Full-Heat · Red sides w/o coat = LV Yin def + Empty-Heat · Red center = ST Heat or ST Empty-Heat
Purple	Blood stasis	Always Blood stasis · Reddish-purple = stasis from Heat · Bluish-purple = stasis from Cold · Reddish-purple sides = LV Blood stasis + Heat · Bluish-purple sides (women) = Blood stasis in Uterus from Cold · Purple center = Blood stasis in Stomach
Blue/Bluish	Interior Cold · Blood stasis	Extreme interior Cold with Blood stasis; Yang Qi unable to warm and move Blood

⚠ **Red Points:** Red tip = Heart; Red sides = LV/GB; Red center = ST; Red front third = Lung. Always note the zone of red points — location tells you the organ.

Shape Finding	Clinical Indication	Zone Note
SWOLLEN / ENLARGED		
Swollen (overall)	Dampness or Phlegm; SP Yang def with water retention; Heat in Blood + Dampness	With pale body = Damp-Cold; with red body = Damp-Heat
Swollen sides (red)	LV/GB Damp-Heat or Fire	Liver area = sides
Swollen tip (red)	Heart-Fire blazing	Heart area = tip
Swollen front third	Lung-Qi def or Phlegm in Lungs	Lung area = front 1/3
Swollen center (pale)	SP-Qi def · teethmarks often present	SP/ST = center oval
THIN / CONTRACTED		
Thin, dry	Blood deficiency; Yin deficiency with Empty-Heat drying fluids	
Thin, wet/moist	Yang deficiency; Cold pattern	
MARKS / TEXTURE		
Teethmarks	SP-Qi def (with swollen body) or Dampness	Often with pale, swollen tongue
Cracked / Fissured	Yin def · Excess Heat consuming fluids · normal variation if lifelong	Central crack = ST; multiple = KD Yin def
Centerline crack	Heat in Stomach; injury to Stomach fluids	Reaches tip = HT; stops in middle = ST
Red points/petechia	Heat or Fire in corresponding zone organ	Tip=HT · Front=LU · Sides=LV · Center=ST
MOVEMENT		
Deviated	Internal Wind; Liver Wind (check trauma first)	Miley Cyrus = yellow coat+deviated → check for trauma
Quivering	SP-Qi def; Blood def	
Moving/Restless	Liver Wind; Internal Wind	
Stiff	Internal Wind; Heat consuming fluids; Phlegm misting Heart	
Flaccid / Limp	Severe Blood or fluid def; extreme Yin def	
Long	Heat in Heart; Heat in Stomach	
Short	Phlegm + Damp in Interior; severe Cold contracting; extreme Blood def	

Color	Indicates
Thin White	Normal; mild/early exterior; Wind-Cold
Thick White	Interior Cold; Damp-Cold; food stagnation
White Sticky/Greasy	Dampness or Phlegm-Cold
Thin Yellow	Exterior Wind-Heat; early Heat
Thick Yellow	Full-Heat; food stagnation with Heat
Yellow Sticky/Greasy	Damp-Heat or Phlegm-Heat
Gray (glossy)	Cold pattern: Damp or Damp-Phlegm
Gray (dry)	Heat pattern: Yin deficiency or extreme Heat
Black (wet)	Extreme Cold; Yang def; Damp-Phlegm
Black (dry)	Extreme Heat; Yin exhaustion
No coat (peeled)	ST Yin def; Stomach fails to produce coat
Thin coat	Normal; mild pathogen; early stage
Thick coat	Pathogenic factor present; stronger = thicker
Total absence (red)	ST + KD Yin def with Empty-Heat

Moisture	Indicates
Slightly moist	Normal — Body Fluids intact
Too wet / Glossy	Yang def; Damp or Phlegm; water accumulation
Too dry	Heat; Yin def; Body Fluid damage
Sticky / Slippery	Dampness and/or Phlegm
Rough / Sandpaper	Severe injury to Body Fluids; extreme Heat
Type	Description & Meaning
Partially peeled	ST Yin and Qi def — some coat remains
Geographic	Scattered areas peeled with raised borders — ST Yin/Qi def
Mirror (total)	No coat, smooth shiny — ST Yin exhausted; severe Yin def
Dappled	Missing patches but new coat growing — transitional state
Coating diagnostic logic: Coat = Yang organs + pathogens. Absence = ST Yin def (can't produce coat). Rootless coat (no attachment, floats) = ST/KD Qi def.	

Tongue Finding	Pattern / Interpretation
Slightly pale, dry	Blood Deficiency
Pale, wet, swollen	Yang Deficiency / Damp-Cold
Pale sides	Liver Blood Deficiency
Pale, swollen center, teethmarks	Spleen Qi Deficiency
Red, yellow coat	Full-Heat (Excess Yang)
Red, no coat (peeled)	Empty-Heat (Yin Deficiency)
Red tip only	Heart-Fire (w/ coat) or HT Empty-Heat (w/o coat)
Red sides, coat	Liver-Fire or GB Full-Heat
Red sides, no coat	Liver Yin Deficiency with Empty-Heat
Purple, reddish	Blood Stasis from Heat
Purple, bluish	Blood Stasis from Cold
Centerline crack (reaches tip)	Heart Heat/Fire; injury to HT fluids
Centerline crack (stops in middle)	Stomach Yin/fluid deficiency
Rootless coat	Stomach Qi or Yin Deficiency
No coat at all, red body	Kidney Yin Deficiency with Empty-Heat
No coat in front third	Lung Yin Deficiency
No coat in center only	Stomach Yin Deficiency
Deviated tongue	Interior/Liver Wind (check trauma first)
Dark distended sublingual veins	Blood Stagnation
Pink body, red HT/LV sides	Heat in Liver and Heart
Purple-red body + swollen center	Blood Stagnation + Heat + Phlegm-Damp in MJ
Dry yellow coat in Middle/Lower Burner	Heat in ST and/or KD

PATTERN NAME	DISEASE CATEGORY	WEEK / QUIZ

ETIOLOGY	ORGAN SYSTEM	DATE

CLINICAL ESSENTIALS · TONGUE · PULSE · TREATMENT PRINCIPLE

CHINESE MEDICINE
TONGUE MAP

COLOR / COAT / SHAPE

Wrist

CUN 寸

GUAN 關

CHI 尺

L HT/SI		LV/GB	KD/BL
R LU/LI		SP/ST	PC/TB

QUALITY / OVERALL

This image shows a full page of white paper with horizontal blue or grey ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page, typical of notebook paper. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the page.

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